

taller than Nancy, which makes it difficult to match our stride frequency, but after many years together, we have learned to do this.

It's very important to coordinate because running as a guide is not just about running as fast as you can. You have to be their eyes, constantly aware of what's happening in the rest of the pack. You need to understand your runner and know whether she has energy or not. At the same time, you have to let her make the decisions. You are guiding someone else. You have to sacrifice your own ambitions to assist another person.

Nancy: I've been blind all my life. I never thought I would be a runner. Even though everyone where I come from runs, I didn't even know what it was. One day in 2015, my brother told me he would make me run. I was very scared at first because I was afraid of tripping and falling. But my brother told me he would guide me, and that made me take the chance. I don't think I would have started running if it wasn't for him. Thanks to him, I've found a path for my own life. I won a bronze in the 1500m at Tokyo Paralympics and gold in the 1500m at the 2023 Paris World Para Athletic Championships. I will continue running as long as my brother runs with me.

'Marcin helped me come out of severe depression'

Runner: Joanna Mazur-Dziedzic

Guide: Marcin Kesy

(Poland)

T11 women's 1500m bronze

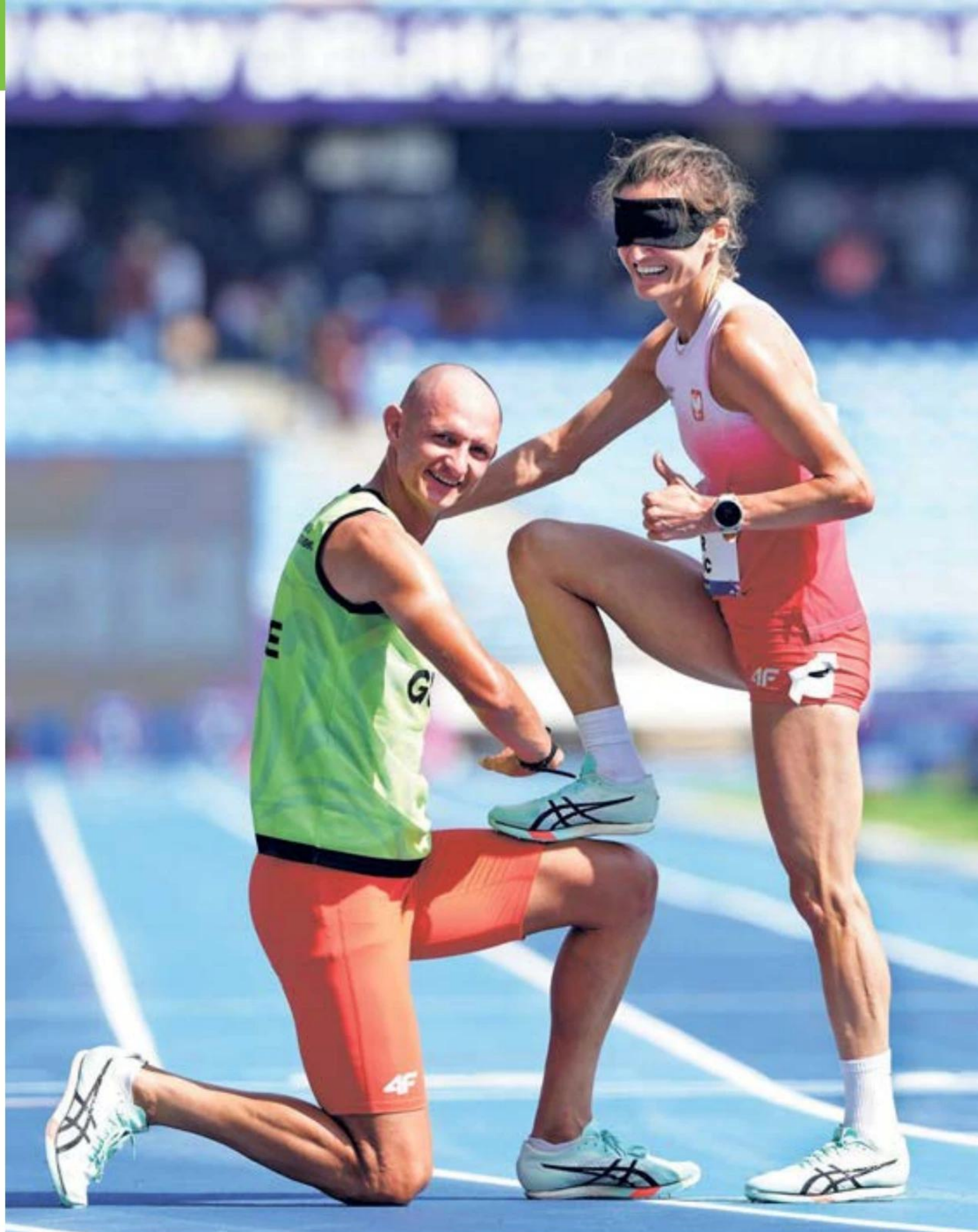
Joanna: I feel pure happiness when I run with Marcin. When you run with a guide for long, you come to depend on them deeply. It's not just about familiarity; it's about trust. I previously had another guide who was also my coach, and things didn't go so well with him. We stopped working together after the Olympics. It was devastating when it happened but it was also for the best. For the last few years, I had been sick with severe depression. Losing my first guide was emotionally very hard for me.

I started running as a way to deal with my emotions when I began

going blind. It helped me overcome the constant feeling of fear. It encouraged me to grow more confident with my surroundings. When I lost my guide, it felt as if all those fears came rushing back.

It took Marcin to get me out of that depression. Six months after the Paralympics, I asked him if he would want to run with me. He agreed almost immediately. His best quality is that he understands me. I enjoy running with him. When I'm stressed, he can feel it. Before the World Championships, I was really nervous and he made jokes so that I would feel relaxed. At other times I cry and then he just listens. He just says, "I'm here with you. Don't be afraid. We are here together."

Marcin: I used to run road races when Joanna asked me to be her



Shared joy: Poland's Joanna Mazur-Dziedzic shares a joyful moment with her guide, Marcin Kesy, after their race at the World Para Athletics Championships. GETTY IMAGES

guide. I saw it as a challenge. There was no question of saying no to her. I noticed that she was not at peace, and my focus was to help her find it again. Running was what gave her confidence once, so I had to help her rediscover that. I'm there to help her only as much as she's willing to take. I can't be faster than her. When she's at the top of her speed, even a small touch can make her dizzy or cause her to fall. So I need to listen not just to my body but to hers. That is always a challenge because I have to make my ambition part of her ambition.